

Non-Directive Play Therapy

Professional Training Programme 2027–2028, Kaunas, Lithuania

Description of the professional development training programme

Brief description of the NDPT training programme

The Non-Directive Play Therapy (NDPT) professional training programme is an 18-month blended, part-time, practice-based professional development course. It runs from January 2027 to June 2028 in the form of extended weekends (Saturday–Sunday): 8 training blocks in total, the last of which lasts three days (Friday–Sunday) and completes the programme. The blocks take place at intervals of approximately two months.

Total programme volume – 150 academic hours: 135 hours of contact teaching across eight modules and 15 hours of self-directed learning.

In addition, 32 hours of group supervision are provided within the programme. Completion requirements include supervised practice (at least 25 individual play therapy sessions with at least two children), external supervision at a ratio of 4:1, and a final assessment of all theoretical and practical assignments.

The programme begins in January, with intensive study until the summer; from the autumn until the following summer, the required play therapy practice and external supervision are added. The training is delivered in Lithuanian. In individual cases, when a guest lecturer from abroad is invited, sessions may be held in English, Russian or Polish (with interpretation if needed, which may involve additional interpretation costs).

What makes the NDPT programme distinctive

It is the only play therapy training programme in Lithuania, developed on the basis of international guidelines and taking into account the requirements for training play therapists.

Most psychotherapy training programmes in our country focus on work with adult clients. There is a serious shortage of specialists prepared to work psychotherapeutically with children and their families. This programme is unique in that it focuses primarily on preschool and early primary school-aged clients and their families.

The training emphasises the quality of non-directive play therapy and the development of practical skills, based on the research-supported system developed by Dr Garry Landreth and other leading representatives of Child-Centred Play Therapy.

The training is also grounded in a humanistic and systemic approach. The core psychotherapy model taught is person-centred psychotherapy, applied in practice to the needs of counselling children and families. Participants receive a grounding in systemic therapy, a model for working with parents while the child attends play therapy, and an introduction to Filial Therapy.

In addition, participants learn to integrate various expressive arts therapy modalities with play therapy, with the aim of preparing specialists for creative practice with a broad range of therapeutic tools.

The supervised clinical practice and theoretical content are oriented towards professional work with child clients across a wide age range and their families, including those with complex needs.

Aims and objectives

Main aim of the programme

- To provide theoretical and practical knowledge and skills in using play therapy with preschool and early primary school-aged children to specialists working with children and families in the fields of mental health and education.

Competences and skills gained

On completing the Non-Directive Play Therapy training programme, the participant will:

1. have acquired the theoretical foundations and core principles of person-centred (humanistic) psychotherapy
2. know the stages of typical child development and the characteristics of play at each stage, as well as aspects of psychological resilience
3. respect and accept the child's world as the child perceives it, and become more empathic and more unconditionally accepting of children and adults
4. be able to recognise a child's emotional (not chronological) age of functioning and adapt therapeutic responses accordingly, to achieve the greatest possible attunement in the therapeutic relationship
5. be able to formulate clients' clinical presentations in a way that supports working towards therapeutic goals
6. have learned to use supervision as an essential tool for continuous growth in play therapy practice
7. be able to identify therapeutic toys and materials suitable for use in a permanent or mobile therapeutic setting, for play therapy or assessment purposes
8. have consolidated a systemic approach in their work and understand the role of the play therapist and the place of play therapy within the wider context of the client's functioning (family, school, community)
9. be able to recognise the stages of the therapeutic process and relationship, from the initial interview to the end of therapy
10. have mastered the core therapeutic skills: tracking, reflecting play content and process, returning responsibility to the child, limit setting, and others
11. be able to involve and support the child client's parents or carers in the therapeutic process as allies of play therapy
12. take on their professional role as a play therapist responsibly and adhere to ethical principles

Applications and career opportunities

The knowledge, competences and skills gained through the NDPT training programme have a wide range of practical applications wherever there is therapeutic work with children and families, particularly with preschool and early primary school-aged children: in kindergartens, primary and lower secondary schools, mental health centres, foster care centres, day centres and family centres.

Programme structure and volume

Course structure

- 18 months, part-time professional training (January 2027 – June 2028)

- Hybrid: in-person teaching at weekends at the premises of the "Menas padėti" Psychotherapy Centre in Kaunas, complemented by online and self-directed learning
- Mixed methods: lectures, experiential learning, creative tasks, group work, discussions, homework, simulation, video training, analysis of therapy video recordings, individual and group supervision, (self-)reflection, and clinical practice directly with clients

Three interwoven and integrated areas of learning

- Theoretical knowledge
- Practical skills
- Personal development

Course content

- The non-directive approach in play therapy, therapeutic skills in work with children, attachment theory, trauma
- Neurobiological aspects of children's play, the child as client and their characteristics, the play therapy process
- The personality of the play therapist, and other topics

Training block plan

Module	Dates	Days	Hrs	Topic
1	16–17 Jan 2027	2	16	Play Therapy Skills I. The person-centred psychotherapeutic approach, Axline's principles
2	6–7 Mar 2027	2	16	Play Therapy Skills II. Theories of play development and pathology
3	22–23 May 2027	2	16	Play Therapy Skills III: therapeutic limits
4	Sep 2027	2	16	Ethics, contracting, working with parents, Filial Therapy, first meeting with the child
5	Nov 2027	2	16	Therapeutic assessment. Trauma, attachment, transference and countertransference
6	Jan 2028	2	16	The play therapy process. Anxiety and aggression
7	Mar 2028	2	16	Ending play therapy. Grief and divorce
8	May 2028	3	23	Integrated arts therapy interventions. Play therapist identity, self-reflection. Final exam, case presentation
	TOTAL	17	135	
Self-study	Ongoing	≈ 2	15	The therapeutic powers of play, the history of play therapy, main theoretical approaches, and other topics
	GRAND TOTAL	17	150	

Hours are academic hours. The dates of the first three modules (January, March and May 2027) are confirmed. The exact dates of the later modules have already been planned and will be confirmed once the training has started.

Session times: Saturday 10:00–18:00, Sunday 9:00–17:00. Sunday starts and ends an hour earlier so that participants travelling from further away can get home in time. The organisers reserve the right to adjust the times to suit the needs of the majority of participants.

There is a summer break between Modules 3 and 4. All supervision and client session logs and homework should be submitted by the final module; the final deadline is 1 July 2028.

Detailed training regulations, including assignments and exact dates, are provided to confirmed participants at the first meeting.

Entry requirements

The programme is intended for experienced professionals who wish to gain competences in therapeutic play, play therapy, child counselling, family counselling, work with parents, and arts-based and other creative therapeutic interventions.

Applicants must hold a master's degree or higher qualification in (mental) health or the social sciences: psychologists, (clinical) social workers, psychiatrists and physicians of other specialisations (neurologists, developmental paediatricians) holding a master's degree or equivalent, as well as resident doctors, psychological well-being consultants, psychotherapists, arts therapists, family therapists, and others with a master's degree or higher qualification in education or related fields whose studies included the following subjects: child development; theories of personality; principles of psychotherapy; child and adolescent psychopathology; cultural and social diversity; and ethics.

Admission process

Required documents

- University degree in the social sciences, health sciences or a related field (copy of master's diploma with transcript of subjects studied)
- Certificate confirming eligibility to work with children (issued with a QR code; the Lithuanian background check for work with children)
- Curriculum vitae (CV)
- At least 2–3 years of experience working with children (certificate or reference from the workplace or workplaces)

Completion requirements and assessed components

The following conditions must be met to successfully complete the course and be awarded the certificate:

ATTENDANCE is required at all eight modules (135 hours). For very serious reasons, only one module may be missed over the 18 months (up to 16 hours). If up to 16 hours are missed, the participant must agree with the organisers how to make up the missed module through additional work at home. If more is missed, the course must be repeated. If unable to attend a module, participants must notify the organisers in advance by email: info@menaspadeti.lt

PRACTICAL ASSIGNMENTS Completion and presentation of practical assignments, ensuring the authenticity of the work and a scholarly standard of presentation. Assignments follow each module; the most important final assignments are the presentation of a practical play therapy case and the final exam. The aim of the final exam is to assess the participant's theoretical knowledge, ability to analyse clinical situations, and application of play therapy principles in professional practice. The final exam consists of a test and open questions covering the material of the whole 18-month course.

SELF-DIRECTED LEARNING Self-directed study through reading recommended material, listening to online lectures (15 hours) and reflecting on the knowledge gained.

PRACTICAL THERAPEUTIC WORK Practical therapeutic work using play therapy with child clients and their families: at least 25 play therapy sessions with at least two children, with the process documented and the practice supervised at the required ratio.

SUPERVISION Active and sincere participation in supervision, discussing play therapy cases and related issues.

Play therapy practice carried out during the training must be supervised at a **ratio of 4:1**: at least one hour of supervision for every four hours of play therapy, and no less than once a month.

As the minimum practice requirement is 25 play therapy sessions, each participant will need at least **6–7 hours of individual or 12–15 hours of group** supervision. Individual and group hours are not equivalent: in group supervision each participant receives less attention, so more hours are needed.

32 hours of group supervision take place during the programme.

Practice supervision **must be external and independent of the training organisers**. The organisers help participants find a supervisor and provide a list of recommended supervisors, but do not take part in the supervision itself or set its terms. External supervision is paid by the participant directly to the supervisor.

Participants choose a supervisor from the recommended list or may find one themselves, in which case they must obtain confirmation from the training organisers that the supervisor's experience and qualifications meet the requirements for play therapy supervision. At the end of the programme, a report from the external supervisor must be submitted, confirming the supervision hours completed and including recommendations for professional growth.

ETHICAL CONDUCT Respect, openness and honesty in following the training regulations, in communication, and in giving and receiving feedback with the programme leaders, lecturers and fellow participants.

The NDPT programme leaders reserve the right not to award the course completion certificate if a participant has not demonstrated the ability to apply play therapy principles in practical work with children and families.

Programme organisers, lecturers and partners

MAIN LECTURERS

Psychologist-psychotherapist, play therapist and supervisor **DALIA GUZAITIENĖ** is the only psychotherapist in Lithuania with a specialisation in play therapy. She completed her training in Humanistic and Integrative Psychotherapy and Play Therapy in Ireland, has trained in Creative Supervision, continues her professional development and practises according to European psychotherapy standards.

Psychologist, psychodynamic psychotherapist, Incredible Years programme facilitator and training consultant **RITA BAGDONAITĖ** specialises in parenting skills training (the Incredible Years programme), foster care and trauma, and work with adolescents and adults.

GUEST LECTURERS AND PARTNERS

ZUZANA DUBENKOVA, MA in Education, child and adolescent psychotherapist, play therapy and Filial Therapy practitioner, who more than a decade ago was the first to bring play therapy training from the

USA to Slovakia and the Czech Republic. She is co-founder of the Play Therapy Institute (PTI – Inštitút Terapie Hrou) and President of the Board of the Slovak-Czech Association for Play Therapy (SCAPT). Zuzana specialises in work with children, adolescents and their parents. She provides parenting consultations, runs Filial Therapy courses and practises play therapy. She also lectures, provides supervision, and leads professional play therapy training programmes in Slovakia and the Czech Republic.

Partners who will be invited to teach and supervise during the training:

Joanna Babinska, child, adolescent and family psychotherapist, play therapist and supervisor (LPC, CPCS, RPT-S, accredited in the USA).

Dr Eimir McGrath, child, adolescent and adult psychologist-psychotherapist, play therapist and supervisor, specialising in trauma, violence, attachment difficulties and disability, in particular complex trauma, dissociative identity disorder and psychotherapy in the context of disability.

Details of guest lectures and supervision are being arranged and will be confirmed once the programme has started.

"Menas padėti" Psychotherapy Centre · Savanorių pr. 363B, Kaunas, Lithuania · +370 649 46466 · info@menaspadeti.lt · www.menaspadeti.lt · Prepared by Dalia Guzaitienė, 30 September 2026